

Post-Exam Year 12

Business Decision Challenges

Three ready-to-teach lessons for the weeks after exams — real UK companies, real 2024 figures, real decisions. No filler, no word searches.

What's inside

Lesson 1 — The Turnaround: ASOS lost £331m. Your class is the new leadership team.

Lesson 2 — The Price Call: Pret's £30-a-month coffee subscription. Keep it, cut it or change it?

Lesson 3 — The Expansion: Greggs after 4pm. Where does £2bn of sausage roll money go next?

Plus: a five-minute starter bank built on BrewDog, Aldi and JD Sports.

Suits A-Level Business (AQA 7132, Edexcel 9BS0, OCR), IB Business Management and BTEC groups in the post-exam window. Each lesson runs 50–60 minutes. Print in grayscale, A4.

Free resource from thebusiness.school

How to run these lessons

The post-exam weeks are awkward: Year 12 are still in the room but the spec pressure is off. These three lessons use that freedom. Each one drops students into a genuine decision a UK business faced in 2024, gives them the real numbers, and makes them commit to a choice and defend it. The thinking is exam-relevant (analysis, evaluation, quantitative skills) but nothing feels like revision.

Timing that works

10 min — read the briefing sheet as a class, clarify the numbers. 25 min — teams of 3–4 work through the task sheet and agree a decision. 15 min — each team presents its call in 90 seconds; class votes; reveal what the company actually did. 10 min — debrief: which arguments used the data, which ignored it?

Ground rules for teams

Every recommendation must quote at least two figures from the briefing. Every team must name the biggest risk of its own plan. A confident wrong answer beats a vague safe one — that is where the debrief lives.

Marking-free zone. Nothing here needs grading. If you want evidence of effort, collect the decision sheets — they double as application/analysis practice for September.

WORKING SPACE

Lesson 1 — The Turnaround: ASOS

Briefing sheet (student copy)

ASOS sells fast fashion online to 16–34 year olds. It owns no shops. For years it was the success story of British online retail — then the numbers turned. In its 2024 financial year ASOS reported revenue of about £2.9 billion, down on the previous year, and an operating loss of about £331 million. Warehouses held too much unsold stock, returns ate margins, and Shein undercut prices. In 2024 ASOS relaunched Topshop, the famous brand it bought out of administration, to pull shoppers back.

Figure (FY2024)	Value	Why it matters
Revenue	≈ £2.9bn	Still a big business — the problem is cost, not demand collapse
Operating result	≈ –£331m loss	Spending more to run the business than it earns from it
Customer base	16–34, online only	Most price-sensitive segment; lowest brand loyalty
Key 2024 move	Topshop relaunch	Betting on brand strength rather than price cuts

Your task — you are the new leadership team

The board gives you one year and one priority. Choose ONE of the three strategies below, or write your own fourth option. Prepare a 90-second pitch.

Option	The bet	The risk you must name
A — Cut to profit	Close a warehouse, sell less, stop discounting. Smaller but profitable.	Revenue shrinks further; can you stop the slide?
B — Brand up	Push Topshop and own-brand ranges. Higher prices, better margins.	Will 16–34s pay more when Shein is one tap away?
C — Price war	Match Shein on price. Defend market share at any cost.	You already lose £331m. How long can you fund this?
D — Your call	Write your own one-year priority.	Name it yourself.

Decision sheet: Our choice: ____ | Two figures that support it: _____ | Biggest risk of our own plan: _____ | How we'd know after 6 months it's working: _____

Teacher debrief

What ASOS actually did: a version of A + B — cut stock levels and warehouse costs, accepted lower sales, and relaunched Topshop to rebuild margin. Useful debrief line: a loss-making firm cannot fight a price war (Option C) without new finance, which links neatly to sources of finance and stakeholder pressure when you return to the spec in September.

Lesson 2 — The Price Call: Pret a Manger

Briefing sheet (student copy)

Pret a Manger sells coffee and food to commuters and office workers. Its subscription, Club Pret, currently costs £30 per month and gives up to five barista drinks a day. It was designed to pull customers back into city centres after the pandemic and lock in repeat visits. The dilemma: heavy users cost Pret money on every drink, light users quietly subsidise them, and every price change makes headlines. When Pret has adjusted the scheme before, cancellations spiked and social media filled with complaints — but footfall stayed strong. A single barista-made drink bought separately costs around £3.50-£4, so one drink a day on the subscription already beats paying at the till.

Fact	Detail	Tension it creates
Subscription price	£30 per month	A daily flat-white habit alone would cost more bought separately
Usage cap	Up to 5 drinks a day	Heaviest users get huge value — at Pret's expense
Customer pattern	Commuters, repeat visits	Subscription drives the habit Pret wants
Past changes	Cancellations spiked, then settled	Loyalty is real but conditional

Your task — pricing committee

Pick ONE move for the next 12 months and defend it with the data:

Option	The move	Question you must answer
A — Hold at £30	Keep the scheme exactly as it is.	If heavy users are loss-making, why keep them?
B — Raise the price	Push towards £35–40 and accept cancellations.	How many cancellations before the maths turns against you?
C — Cut the cap	Keep £30 but limit drinks to 2 per day.	Is a quieter change more or less honest than a price rise?
D — Scrap it	End subscriptions; simple menu prices.	What happens to the daily habit you built?

Decision sheet: Our move: ____ | The customer we are willing to lose: ____ | Two figures or facts behind our call: ____ | The headline we fear next morning: ____

Teacher debrief

Unlike Lessons 1 and 3 there is no tidy company reveal here - Pret keeps tweaking the scheme, so let the class vote stand as the verdict. There is no clean right answer, which is the point. Strong teams will spot that the subscription is really a customer-retention tool, not a profit line — so judging it on drink-level margin misses why it exists. Links forward to price elasticity, contribution and non-financial objectives.

Lesson 3 — The Expansion: Greggs

Briefing sheet (student copy)

Greggs is one of the most reliable growth stories on the UK high street: around 2,600 shops and revenue of about £2.01 billion in its 2024 financial year. Its problem is a nice one to have — where does the next phase of growth come from? Most Greggs sales happen before 4pm. The company has been pushing evening trading: later opening hours, pizza boxes and hot food aimed at the after-work crowd. At the same time it keeps opening new shops, moving beyond high streets into retail parks, supermarkets and petrol stations.

Figure (FY2024)	Value	Why it matters
Revenue	≈ £2.01bn	Growth must now come on top of a very large base
Shop estate	≈ 2,600 UK shops	High street saturation is a real question
Sales pattern	Mostly before 4pm	Shops sit half-used through the evening
Current pushes	Evening menus; retail parks, travel hubs	Two different bets running at once

Your task — growth committee

The board will fund ONE priority properly. Choose where the next £100m of investment goes:

Option	The bet	The risk you must name
A — Own the evening	Refit shops for evening food; staff later hours nationwide.	Is Greggs a brand people want at 8pm, or a breakfast habit?
B — More shops	Hundreds of new sites in retail parks, stations, petrol forecourts.	Each new site is cheaper than the last is worth — until it isn't
C — Go upmarket	New format cafes, better coffee, higher prices.	Does premium Greggs cannibalise the £1.30 sausage roll?
D — Your call	Delivery-only kitchens? International? Make the case.	Name it yourself.

Decision sheet: Our £100m goes to: ____ | Two figures that support it: _____ | Biggest risk of our own plan: _____ | What we would measure monthly: _____

Teacher debrief

Greggs is in practice running A and B together — evening trading to sweat existing assets, plus relentless new openings away from traditional high streets. Good debrief angle: Option A grows revenue per shop, Option B grows the number of shops — two completely different operations problems wearing the same logo. Links forward to capacity utilisation and investment appraisal.

Five-minute starter bank

Quick-fire openers for any post-exam lesson. Put the fact on the board, give pairs three minutes, take answers cold.

#	The fact on the board	The question
1	BrewDog's net profit margin in its most recent accounts was roughly –18%. The bars stayed busy.	How does a business survive years of losses? Name three ways it keeps paying the bills.
2	Aldi employs about 45,000 people in the UK. Its staff turnover is about 14% against a sector norm of about 21%.	Lower turnover than rivals — what does it save, in money and in things money can't easily count?
3	JD Sports spends about £236m a year on marketing and has 6.8m Instagram followers.	If you cut that budget in half for one year, what happens — and when does it show up?
4	Aldi pays graduate Area Managers around £50,000 to start.	Why would a discounter famous for low prices pay above-market salaries to 22-year-olds?
5	Greggs sells most of its food before 4pm but pays rent 24 hours a day.	Name two industries with the same problem and what they do about it.

Why these work: each one is a real trade-off with no textbook answer. The follow-up that always lands: *"What number would you need to see before you decided?"*

WORKING SPACE

Want your students to make these calls for real?

The Business School is a browser-based business simulation built for exactly this kind of lesson. Students join with a PIN — no accounts, no installs — and run their own company in teams: setting prices, taking loans, hiring staff, filing VAT and negotiating deals, in one 60-minute session. You get a teacher dashboard and automatic grading at the end.

Free pilot for schools

We're inviting business teachers to trial it with a class and tell us what to fix. Details and the pilot form at thebusiness.school

If this pack saved you a planning evening, there's more where it came from — the teachers' group shares a new free resource most weeks.

Sources: company annual reports and results statements FY2024 (ASOS plc, Greggs plc), company pricing pages (Pret a Manger Club Pret), reported figures 2024 (BrewDog plc accounts, Aldi UK recruitment and Kantar-reported data, JD Sports plc).

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